



Jean Louis Hardy

# The Laws of Change.

Twelve principles for becoming the change agent.

A taste of the Change Agent tool.



Nobody reads a toolbox  
from left to right.

So do not read this book that way either.

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# How this book works

*And how to read it without ruining it.*

Most books are built like a long speech at a wedding. You sit through all of it, in order, and you are not allowed to leave until the cake. This one is built like a toolbox. You open it because the sink is leaking.

So relax. You do not have to finish this book. You have to use it.

## This book is a taste

The Laws of Change are 281 principles in all. They live in the Change Agent tool, an online system built for one job: helping you close the gap in your own life. You type in the problem in front of you, in your own words, and the tool shows you the principles that fit, each with its story, what it means, and a move to make. You can read them or listen to them.

This book holds just twelve of those principles. It is a taste. The goal is for you to learn a few, try them on your own life, and see for yourself why the tool is worth using.

Members of our research group get full access to the Change Agent tool and discuss their findings through the community. You will find out how to join at the end of this book.

## One idea, said at four sizes

The whole book is one idea. You have one job, and that job is to close the gap between where things are and where they should be. That is true of a company, a marriage, a waistline, a prayer life, and a Tuesday.

Everything after that is the same idea at a smaller size, the way a map can show you the country, then the state, then the town, then the street. One job. Nine foundations. Five roots. Two hundred eighty-one principles at the time of this writing. This little book gives you the job, the thinking behind it, and twelve of the principles, so you can feel how the whole thing works in your own hands.

## Read it slowly. I mean it.

The famous book is called *Think and Grow Rich*. It is not called *Skim and Grow Rich*. Read one principle, do the move it asks for, and give it a few days before you read the next. The reader who finishes this in an afternoon has won a race nobody else was running.

## Ask one question of every page

How does this apply? That is the only question. A page may talk about a bridge and be secretly about your marriage. A page about a hospital may fix your Monday. The principles do not care which room of your life you carry them into.

## Start with your gap, not with page one

Before you read further, write two sentences. Where are you now? Where do you want to be? Be honest about the first and specific about the second. Then read with that gap in your hand. The book

gets about ten times more interesting when it is about you, which, as a rule, is true of most things.

## How each principle is built

Every principle follows the same six steps, so you always know where you are.

1. **A drawing.** A simple picture of the idea. The filled shape is where you are now. The open one is where you are going. Red marks the gap between them.
2. **A name and one line.** Short enough to remember and to repeat.
3. **A true story.** People forget arguments, but they remember stories. Every story in this book is real, and every one has been checked.
4. **What it means.** The idea in plain words.
5. **If this is you.** Written for the person who is tired and not sure where to go next.
6. **The move.** One small thing to do today.

Each principle then ends with one line to carry with you, and a pointer to related principles in the Change Agent tool.

## A word about the word law

I call these the Laws of Change, and I owe you some honesty about that. Some of them are laws in the strict sense. They are measured, they predict, and they bill you whether or not you agree. Some are patterns, which are real but have exceptions. And some are counsel, which is old wisdom no instrument can measure and which, for the purpose of living a life, is worth more than most laws.

Bet the company on a law. Bet a test on a pattern. Bet your character on counsel. And if you disagree with a page, wonderful. Test it. The answer is in the test, not in your head, and not in mine either. It is founded in real-life application.

## Where these came from

I did not invent most of what is in here. Most of what works is old. My part was to gather it, test it, put it in plain words, and tie every piece to the one job. I'm now ready for others in the world to experience the Laws of Change. All 281 principles, with the person each one came from, live in the Change Agent tool, which is open to members of our research group.

## One last thing

You picked up a book about closing gaps, so hopefully you can already see one in your life. Maybe you lie awake at two in the morning doing the math on money that will not add up. Maybe you are the one everybody counts on at work, and you come home with nothing left for your wife and kids. Maybe the doctor used a word like “pre-diabetic” and you have not told anyone. Maybe you pray less than you used to, and you feel guilty about it. Maybe you built something real, and it still feels empty when the house is quiet. You are tired. You know you are meant for more. And you do not know where to start.

That is a good sign. It hurts because you can picture something better than what you have now. Not everyone can.

Most people feel behind. Maybe you do too. But you are not behind. You know where you want to go, and that already puts you ahead of most people. This book will help you take the first step.

# From wandering to order

*Why doing less, in the right order, gets you there faster.*

Maybe you are tired in a way that sleep does not fix. Your days are full. You are busy from your first coffee to your last email. But if someone asked you what actually changed this year, you would have a hard time answering.

Most people think the answer is to do more. Work longer. Try harder. Add another goal. That feels right, but it usually makes things worse. Doing too little is not your problem.

Think about the junk drawer in your kitchen. Batteries, takeout menus, dead pens, a key to a house you moved out of years ago. Every item in there is useful. But because everything is thrown in together, you have to spend an enormous amount of time to find what you need, if you find it at all. The drawer does not need more stuff. It needs order.

Your life works the same way. You probably have plenty of goals, plenty of ideas and plenty of effort. What is missing is order: knowing what comes first, and letting the rest wait.

That is the whole book in one line. You do not need to do more. You need to do less, but better, in the right order.

## One job

This whole book, and the 281 principles behind it, does one job. It helps you close the gap between where things are and where they should be. There is where you stand, where you need to be, and the distance between. That is true of your health, your family, your faith, and your work. Everything else is detail.

Seen that way, a hundred scattered worries collapse into a handful of gaps, each with a shape you can work on. That alone takes some of the tired out of it.

## The wandering generality

Zig Ziglar, the salesman and teacher, used to tell his audiences that you can be a “wandering generality” or a “meaningful specific.” The wandering generality wants to do better, get healthy, grow the business, be a better dad. Those are lovely wishes. They are also impossible to finish, which is why they so rarely get started. A generality has no front door.

The meaningful specific knows the address. Not “get healthy” but “walk thirty minutes, five mornings a week, through June.” Not “grow the business” but “ten new clients by March 31.” It sounds smaller. It is actually much bigger, because it can be done.

## Less, but better

Dieter Rams spent more than thirty years as the head of design at Braun, the German company that made radios, record players and electric razors. He was known for what he left off. If a button or a line did not need to be there, it went. When he summed up his life’s work, he used three words: less, but better. He was talking about radios. It works just as well on a life.

Here is what that means for you. You get a fixed amount of energy each day, like a paycheck. Split it eight ways and every part gets a little. Your health gets a little. Your marriage gets a little. Your business, your faith and your kids each get a little. None of it gets enough to actually change. So a year goes by, everything is about where it was, and you are more tired than when you started.

Now put most of that same paycheck into one or two things for a season. Same person. Same hours. But this time something moves. The weight comes off. The business turns a corner. Your wife notices you are actually there at dinner. And a win does something busyness never does: it gives you energy back, so the next thing gets easier.

That is why less is not lazy. The person doing twelve things at sixty percent feels busy and stays stuck. The person doing three things well feels almost too calm, and a year later wonders why so much changed. Less, but better, is how the gap actually closes.

## Set things in order

Order is an old-fashioned word, and it deserves a comeback. It does not mean rigid. It means each thing in its place, and the first thing first. Every builder knows this. You pour the foundation before you raise the walls, and nobody argues about the sequence, because the sequence is the building.

The three parts of this book follow that same sequence.

- **Part 1. See the gap.** Name where you are and where you are going, honestly and exactly.
- **Part 2. Less, but better.** Cut until what is left can actually be carried.

- **Part 3. Set things in order.** Put what remains in sequence, from the year down to this morning, and keep it there.

## Why this book points somewhere else

Here is the catch with any book, this one included. You read it, you nod, and three weeks later life is loud again. The problem was never a shortage of good advice. It was having the right principle in front of you on the day you need it, and someone to try it with.

That is why we built two things. The Change Agent tool holds all 281 principles. You tell it what you are facing, and it hands you the ones that fit. The Research Group is the people. We take the principles into real homes and real companies, try them, and compare notes on what held up. The tool gives you the order. The group keeps you in it.

This book is the front door. Twelve principles, so you can feel how it works. If they help, there are 269 more waiting for you.

## How to use the twelve

Read one. Do the move. Live with it for a few days before you read the next. Twelve principles, practiced, will change more than three hundred, admired. Which, if you think about it, is the whole argument of the book.

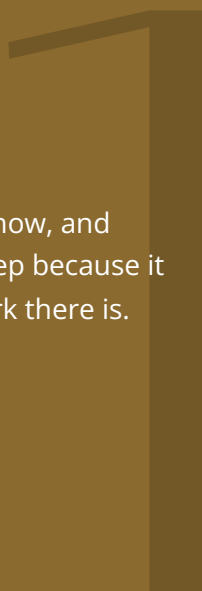
Turn the page. Let's find out where you are standing.



PART 1 OF 3

# See the gap

Before you fix anything, see it. Where exactly is it now, and where exactly must it be? Most people skip this step because it feels like not working. It is the most important work there is.



1



PRINCIPLE 1 OF 281 · THE GAP

Change is the distance between  
two states

# The Gap

*Change is the distance between two states*

For almost two hundred years, people wanted to get from England to France without getting wet. In 1802 a French engineer drew a tunnel lit by oil lamps, with an island halfway across where travelers could change horses. In the 1880s two crews actually started digging and got more than a mile out. Then the British army stopped it, afraid the French would use the tunnel to walk in. In 1974 they tried again. Within a year that was cancelled too, because the costs had doubled and the country was short of money.

So when the last attempt began in December 1987, the Channel Tunnel was less a project than a long list of reasons it would never happen.

This time two crews started on opposite coasts, one in England and one in France, with about twenty-three miles of seabed between them and as much as 250 feet of rock and water above their heads. At the peak, fifteen thousand people worked on it. The two crews could not see each other and could not shout across. What they had was two very exact points: where they stood and where they had to meet. Every day, instruments told them how far they had drifted off the line.

On December 1, 1990, a British tunneler named Graham Fagg broke through the last of the chalk and shook hands with a Frenchman named Philippe Cozette. After three years of digging blind from

opposite ends, the two tunnels were off by about a foot sideways and three inches up and down. And Fagg's machine had set off from the very tunnel the 1974 crew had walked away from.

The dream had not changed in two hundred years. What changed was that this time, somebody measured.

## What it means

Every change you will ever make has the same shape. There is where you are now, where you need to be, and the distance between them. That is all change is. It is not an event, a mood, or a Monday. It is a distance. A distance can be measured, and anything you can measure, you can close one step at a time.

## If this is you

Maybe you opened this book because something feels off and you cannot name it. You are tired. You know you are meant to grow, but every direction looks the same, so you stay put, and staying put makes you more tired. That is not a flaw in you. It is what it feels like to dig in the dark without your two points. You spend effort every day and none of it adds up, because nothing tells you whether you moved.

You do not need a bigger push. You need the two points. The gap might be your health, a marriage that has gone quiet, your walk with God, or a business that eats your evenings. It might be all four. Start with one. And if you have tried before, maybe more than once, those attempts are not wasted. Fagg started from the tunnel somebody else quit. You get to start from where you stopped.

**The move.** Get a sheet of paper. Pick one area of your life that is bothering you: your health, your family, your faith or your work. Then write two sentences about it.

1. **Where is it now?** Just the facts, no blame. Write it the way a doctor reads a chart, not the way a critic writes a review. For example: "I weigh 240 pounds." Or: "My son and I have not had a real talk since spring."
2. **Where does it need to be?** Be just as specific. For example: "I weigh 200 pounds by next June." Or: "My son and I have a real talk once a week."

Now you can see your gap. At the end of each day this week, ask yourself one question: did the gap get smaller today? Even a small yes counts. That is how tunnels get built.

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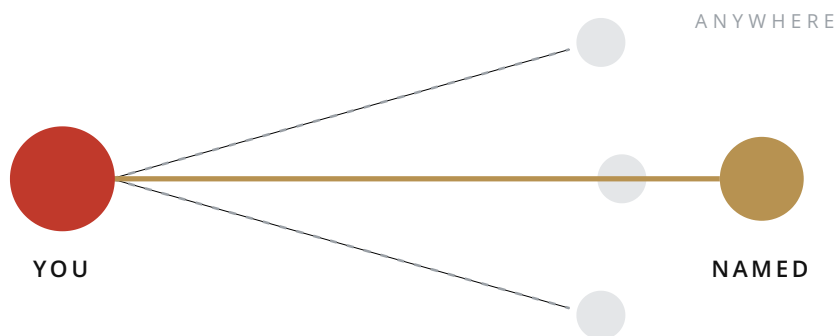
#### CARRY THIS

You are not lost. You are unmeasured.

#### GO DEEPER IN THE CHANGE AGENT TOOL

Related principles in the tool: From Dream to Delivery, The War Map and The Four Engines of Change. Or type in your own problem, like "I feel stuck and don't know where to start," and the tool finds the principles that fit. Research Group members can open every one of them.

# 2



## PRINCIPLE 2 OF 281 · THE GAP

An unnamed gap cannot be closed

# Name the Destination

*An unnamed gap cannot be closed*

On a dark October night in 1707, four British warships ran onto the rocks of the Scilly Isles, and somewhere between 1,400 and 2,000 sailors drowned. Their navigators had not known where they were. At sea, working out how far north you were was easy enough. Working out how far east or west, your longitude, was close to guesswork, and guesswork was sinking ships.

For years the answers came as hopeful pamphlets and clever theories. Then, in 1714, Parliament did something governments rarely do. It said exactly what it wanted: twenty thousand pounds to anyone who could fix a ship's longitude to within half a degree, about thirty nautical miles. Not "improve navigation." Half a degree.

A Lincolnshire carpenter named John Harrison read that law like a work order. He had no university training, and his first clocks ran on works made entirely of wood. He spent five years on his first sea clock and seventeen on his third, and each one taught him what the last had gotten wrong. In the end he shrank the whole idea into something that looked like an oversized pocket watch. He called it H4.

On November 18, 1761, H4 left Portsmouth for Jamaica aboard HMS Deptford, with Harrison's son William looking after it. Eighty-one days later it was five seconds slow. That is an error of about one nautical mile, against a target of thirty.

The Board of Longitude called it luck and demanded more trials. Harrison was eighty years old when Parliament finally paid him 8,750 pounds in 1773. But the number had already done its real work. For three decades it told one stubborn carpenter exactly what to aim at.

## What it means

Vague goals are popular for an excellent reason: you can never fail one. Nobody has ever missed the target of "getting healthier." That is also why nobody has ever hit it. A gap has two ends, and you cannot see a distance whose far end is fog. Your GPS will cheerfully route you to 1200 Main Street. Type in "somewhere better" and it just sits there. The Roman Stoic Seneca made the same point about ships: if you do not know which port you are sailing for, no wind is favorable. You will travel through life either way. Naming the port is what turns travel into progress.

## If this is you

Maybe you work hard and still feel like you are drifting. That is not laziness. It is a target made of fog. "Get in shape." "Be there more for the kids." "Get closer to God." "Fix the business." Each is a fine wish, and none can ever tell you that you made it, so every day ends with a quiet sense of falling short. A man can carry hard work for years. It is the not knowing that wears him down.

Harrison had something you can have before lunch: a number that told him when he was done. "Walk thirty minutes, five days a week, through June." "Dinner with no phones, four nights a week." "One chapter of Proverbs every morning this month." Named like that, a goal stops accusing you and starts giving directions. A gap you can see both ends of is a gap you can cross.

### The move.

1. Pick the one area that weighs on you most: faith, health, family or work.
2. Write the destination the way Parliament wrote the prize: what exactly, how much, by when. What number would prove you arrived?
3. Give it the stranger test. Could someone who has never met you read it and tell whether you made it? If not, rewrite it until they could.
4. Put it where you will see it tomorrow morning.

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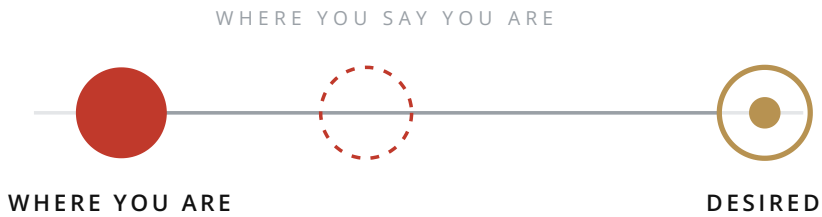
### CARRY THIS

You can't arrive at somewhere better. Pick an address.

### GO DEEPER IN THE CHANGE AGENT TOOL

Related principles in the tool: The Mission Is the How, Write the Source Code and The North Star Number. Or type in your own problem, like "I don't know what I want," and the tool finds the principles that fit. Research Group members can open every one of them.

# 3



## PRINCIPLE 3 OF 281 · THE GAP × THE INSTRUMENT

Measure the gap from the truth,  
not the story

# Stand Where You Stand

*Measure the gap from the truth, not the story*

**E**rnest Shackleton had been sent home from Antarctica once already. In 1903, on Robert Scott's Discovery expedition, his health broke down after the push south, and Scott put him aboard the relief ship Morning, bound for home. He spent the next years raising money to come back and lead the attempt himself.

On October 29, 1908, he set out for the South Pole with three men, Frank Wild, Eric Marshall and Jameson Adams, and four ponies. The ponies did not last. On December 7 the last of them, Socks, vanished down a crevasse and very nearly took Wild with it. The men hauled the sledges themselves, climbed a huge glacier they named the Beardmore, and pulled up onto the polar plateau. Nobody had ever been so far south.

He had already cut the rations twice. Then the arithmetic stopped working. On January 4, 1909, Shackleton accepted that the food could not carry them to the pole and back, and set a smaller goal: get within a hundred geographical miles. On January 9, at 88 degrees 23 minutes south, 97 miles short, they planted a flag and turned around.

The march home nearly killed them. On January 31, Shackleton pressed his own breakfast biscuit on Wild, who was weaker. Wild wrote in his diary, "Thousands of pounds would not have bought that one biscuit." By March 4 all four men were aboard the ship, starving, frostbitten and alive. His wife Emily later recalled his only comment about the pole: "a live donkey is better than a dead lion, isn't it?"

Every instinct he owned said keep walking. He counted instead. The honest number cost him the pole, and it gave him back four lives.

## What it means

The most useful thing on a mall directory is not the list of stores. It is the little red dot that says You Are Here. Without it, the finest map in the world is decoration. Most of us are careful about the far end of a gap and oddly relaxed about the near one, and there is a reason: the flattering version of where we stand feels better, so we quietly move the dot. The psychologist Carl Rogers noticed something that sounds backward. People start to change at the moment they accept, plainly, where they are. An honest starting point is not pessimism. It is where every real route begins.

## If this is you

Maybe the story you tell about your life is a little nicer than the life. Things are fine at home. The business is growing. You are getting back in shape, and you have been saying so since last spring. None of this is lying, exactly. It is what a tired man does to keep going. But it costs you, because every plan you make starts from a dot you are not standing on.

Shackleton was a proud man, a hundred miles from the prize of his life, and he still counted the food. You can count too. The scale. The bank balance. The last time you prayed and meant it. The last real talk with your wife. Those numbers are not insults. They are directions. And here is the quiet gift in a hard number: from where you truly stand, every step you take finally counts.

### The move.

1. Pick one area: faith, health, family or work.
2. Count what is actually there. Money in the account. Months of runway. Hours of sleep last week. Nights home for dinner.  
Write the numbers down with no comment.
3. Ask: does this match the story I tell people?
4. Where it does not, the number wins. Move your dot.

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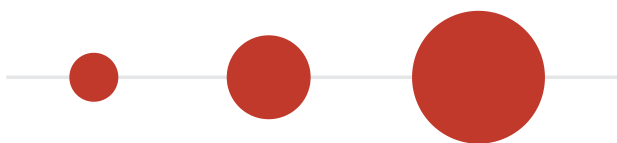
### CARRY THIS

Move the dot to where you actually stand.

### GO DEEPER IN THE CHANGE AGENT TOOL

Related principles in the tool: Memory Is Not Evidence, Put a Number on It and Be Your Own Doctor. Or type in your own problem, like “I keep telling myself it's fine,” and the tool finds the principles that fit. Research Group members can open every one of them.

# 41



THE PRICE OF STAYING · EVERY MONTH, BIGGER

THE FIX · ONCE

PRINCIPLE 41 OF 281 · THE GAP × NATURAL LAW

Doing nothing is the most  
expensive option

# The Cost of Staying

*Doing nothing is the most expensive option*

In the middle of the 1800s, London was the largest city in the world, and it poured its sewage straight into the Thames. The new flush toilets made things worse, sending more waste through old drains that emptied into the river. The same river supplied much of the city's drinking water.

London paid for it in funerals. Cholera killed 14,137 Londoners in 1848 and 1849, and another 10,738 in 1853 and 1854. Most doctors blamed bad air. A physician named John Snow argued that the disease traveled in dirty water, and in 1854 he traced one outbreak in Soho to a single street pump. Few people listened. Plans for proper sewers were drawn, argued over and sent back. Nothing was built.

Then came the hot summer of 1858. The river stank so badly that the Houses of Parliament, right on its bank, soaked their curtains in chloride of lime, and lawmakers could hardly sit. Benjamin Disraeli, then in charge of the nation's finances, called the river "a Stygian pool, reeking with ineffable and intolerable horrors." A bill was debated in late July and became law on August 2.

The engineer Joseph Bazalgette then built 82 miles of main sewers and about 1,100 miles of street sewers, using some 318 million bricks, to carry the waste away downstream. When cholera came back in 1866, it was confined to a part of the East End not yet connected to his system. It was the last cholera outbreak London ever had.

Nearly twenty-five thousand deaths had not been enough. A bad smell under the noses of the people in charge was. The cost of staying had been there all along. It just had not reached the right nostrils.

## What it means

Doing nothing has superb marketing. It never sends an invoice. A fix arrives as one big, ugly number. Staying put arrives as a thousand small ones, spread so thin across the months that you never see the total. Avoiding the big number is not foolish. It is a reasonable response to what is in front of you, the same reason a gym membership you never use can survive for years. The psychologists Daniel Kahneman and Amos Tversky showed that losses loom larger than gains, so the risk of changing feels bigger than the slow bleed of staying. Price the gap before you price the bridge.

## If this is you

Maybe there is something you have meant to deal with for years. The knee you keep working around. The partner who should have been let go. The argument with your brother that nobody has mentioned since the funeral. You have not fixed it because fixing it looks expensive, in money, in pain or in pride.

But look at what you are paying now. The sleep you lose. The way your shoulders tighten in the driveway before a family dinner. The deals you never chase because the old problem eats the hours. You are already paying for the fix. You are just not getting it. That is no cause for shame. You did what anyone does with a bill that never arrives. Now you can write the bill yourself, and once you see the monthly total, the bridge starts to look cheap.

### **The move.**

1. Pick one problem you have left alone for more than a year.
2. On one sheet, make four columns: money, sleep, health and peace.
3. Put a monthly cost in each. Guess where you must, but write something down.
4. Say the total out loud.
5. Then ask what it would cost to fix it once.

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### **CARRY THIS**

Doing nothing never sends a bill. You pay anyway.

### **GO DEEPER IN THE CHANGE AGENT TOOL**

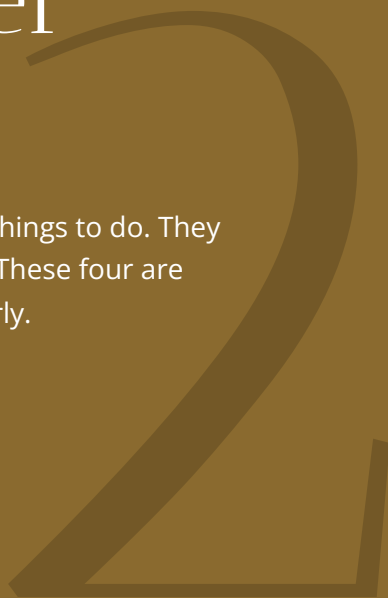
Related principles in the tool: Does It Make the Boat Go Faster, The First 30 Days and All Out Beats Almost. Or type in your own problem, like “I keep putting it off,” and the tool finds the principles that fit. Research Group members can open every one of them.



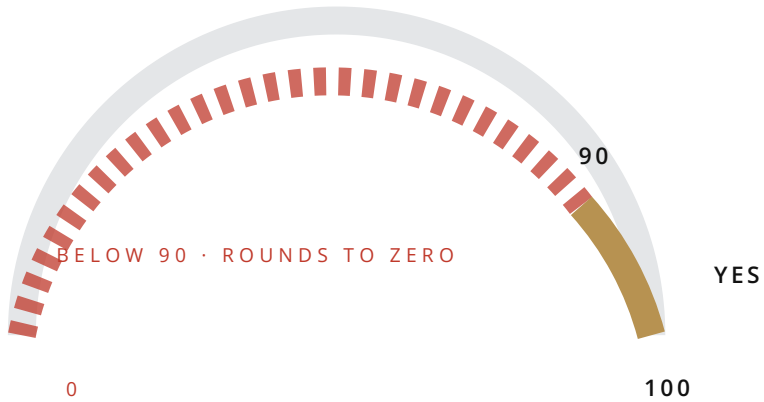
PART 2 OF 3

# Less, but better

Now cut. Most stuck people are not short of things to do. They are carrying too many, each at sixty percent. These four are about choosing fewer and doing them properly.



# 199



PRINCIPLE 199 OF 281 · THE INSTRUMENT

If it isn't a clear yes, it's a clear no

# The Clear Yes

*If it isn't a clear yes, it's a clear no*

In the 1990s, whether a British patient got an expensive new medicine could depend on where he lived. One hospital paid for it. The next one over did not. People called it the postcode lottery (we would say zip code), and the public found it hard to stomach.

So in April 1999 the government set up the National Institute for Clinical Excellence, known as NICE, to decide what the National Health Service should pay for, for everyone. That sounds like a job about saying yes. It is mostly a job about saying no to things that work. The problem is simple. The health service has a fixed budget. If every new drug that helped at all got bought, the money would quietly come out of hip replacements, nurses and screening somewhere else. Nobody would ever see the patients who lost out. They do not get a press conference.

So NICE settled on one number before the drugs arrived: what a treatment costs for each extra year of good quality life it buys. Under about twenty thousand pounds a year was accepted. Above thirty thousand, there had to be increasingly strong reasons. Drugs for Alzheimer's and for kidney cancer were rejected or restricted, and NICE took the anger for it.

Even the exceptions were written down ahead of time. In November 2008 the government let the line rise for cancer drugs at the end of life. A myeloma drug called lenalidomide had first been turned down

as too costly. Its maker, Celgene, then agreed to pay for anyone who stayed on it past about two years. The drug met the written end of life rules and came through in 2009 at 43,800 pounds.

A no decided before the pressure arrives is a no you can actually keep.

## What it means

Here is an odd thing about full calendars: they are almost never full of bad choices. Bad choices are easy to refuse. They are full of fine ones, each of which passed the lazy test of "is there any reason to say no?" The writer Greg McKeown, building on Derek Sivers, offers a stricter test. Name the one thing that matters most before the options show up. Score each option against it, zero to one hundred. Anything under ninety counts as zero. It feels harsh. It is simply honest about the price of a good yes, which is the great yes it blocks.

## If this is you

You are tired, and if you look closely, very little of what tires you was a bad decision. It was the reasonable client. The committee that needed one more person. The favor for a friend, the second project, the dinner you could not really skip. Each one made sense. Together they ate the evenings that were supposed to belong to your kids, your training, your time with God.

That is not weakness. It is generosity without a line drawn in advance. A real yes tends to arrive as appetite. If you catch yourself building a case, collecting reasons, talking yourself into it, the answer is already in. It is a no that has put on a suit.

The good news is that you only need to draw the line once. After that, most decisions make themselves, and the great yes finally has somewhere to sit.

### **The move.**

1. Write one sentence: what matters most in this season of your life?
2. List the next three requests or opportunities on your desk.
3. Score each against that sentence, zero to one hundred.
4. Anything under ninety gets a kind, short no today, in one sentence, with no long explanation.

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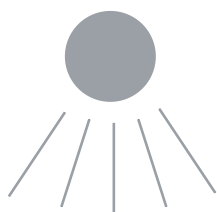
### **CARRY THIS**

Draw the line before the pressure arrives.

#### **GO DEEPER IN THE CHANGE AGENT TOOL**

Related principles in the tool: Decide Once, Guard the Empty Space and Work Fills Its Container. Or type in your own problem, like "I can't say no," and the tool finds the principles that fit. Research Group members can open every one of them.

# 128



SPREAD · WARMTH, NOTHING MORE



FOCUSED · FIRE

PRINCIPLE 128 OF 281 · NATURAL LAW × THE GAP

Same energy, focused, burns

# The Magnifying Glass

*Same energy, focused, burns*

I n 1988 Jimmy Carter and his wife Rosalynn visited Denchira, a village in Ghana of about five hundred people. Nearly half of them had Guinea worm. Carter saw a young woman he thought was cradling a baby. Up close, he saw it was her swollen breast, with a worm coming out of it.

Guinea worm starts with a drink of pond water carrying tiny water fleas, and the fleas carry the larvae. About a year later a female worm, often around three feet long, pushes out through a burning blister, usually on the leg or foot. There is no vaccine and no medicine. The only treatment is to wind the worm slowly around a stick, a little each day, for weeks. And here is the cruel part. The burning makes people put their legs in water to cool them, which is exactly when the worm releases its larvae. The disease runs on a perfectly sensible human reaction.

When the Carter Center took over the campaign in 1986, about 3.5 million people a year were infected across twenty-one countries in Africa and Asia. Big health organizations had mostly stayed away. The patients were poor and remote. The Center did not try ten things. It did a few, everywhere, for decades: cloth filters to strain drinking water, larvicide in the ponds, keeping people with emerging worms out of the water, and village volunteers who checked every suspected case, nearly always within a day.

In 2015 Carter said he hoped the last Guinea worm would die before he did. He died on December 29, 2024, at one hundred. In January 2026 the Center announced the count for 2025: ten human cases in the whole world.

No breakthrough beat the worm. A narrow beam, held still for forty years, did.

## What it means

There is sunlight on every field in the world, and almost none of it starts a fire. Put a cheap lens in the way and the same light burns a hole in a leaf. The line usually credited to Alexander Graham Bell says it plainly: the sun's rays do not burn until brought to a focus. You get roughly the same daily energy as everyone else. Sleep and food might triple it. Focus can multiply it far more. Split it across eight fronts and each gets a flicker. Narrow it to one and it burns. The only way to do more is to do less.

## If this is you

Count the fronts you are fighting on. A new eating plan. A side venture. A reading list. A fresh start with prayer. Fixing things at home. A bit of each, every week, and none of them moving. So you conclude that you are short on energy, or discipline, or both, and you feel worse.

You are not short on energy. You are short on a lens. A person who gives five things ten minutes each will feel busier and see less than a person who gives one thing fifty. That is not a character flaw. It is optics.

Maybe the one is your health, because everything else runs on it. Maybe it is your marriage, or your walk with God. Pick it and starve the rest for a season. The Carter Center beat an ancient disease with cloth and patience. You can move one thing.

### **The move.**

1. Write down every front you are fighting on right now, big and small.
2. Circle the one that would change the most if it moved.
3. Pick two others and put them on hold for thirty days. Tell one person, so the pause is a decision and not a lapse.
4. Put the time you freed on the calendar, against the circled one.

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### **CARRY THIS**

Narrow the beam until it burns.

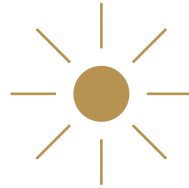
#### **GO DEEPER IN THE CHANGE AGENT TOOL**

Related principles in the tool: One Lane, The 80/20 Law and The Priority Equation. Or type in your own problem, like "I'm spread too thin," and the tool finds the principles that fit. Research Group members can open every one of them.

147



LAYERED TOLERANCE · DULL CORE



SUBTRACTED · SHARP AGAIN

PRINCIPLE 147 OF 281 · THE INSTRUMENT

Every added stimulus blunts the  
instrument

# Sharpen by Subtraction

*Every added stimulus blunts the instrument*

Walk onto a hospital heart unit and the first thing you notice is the sound. Beeps, chimes and alarms, day and night. Most of them mean nothing urgent. A sensor slipped off a finger. A heart rate brushed a limit for a moment and came back by itself. So nurses learn to tune them out, which sounds careless until you picture living with a smoke detector that goes off every time you make toast. The trouble is that the alarm that matters sounds just like the hundred that do not. Hospitals call this alarm fatigue.

At Boston Medical Center, the cardiology unit was averaging 12,546 audible monitor alarms a day. The noise on the floor ran around ninety decibels. When nurses were asked whether the noise level was acceptable, not one of them said yes.

The natural instinct with a safety problem is to add something: more staff, more screens, a louder alarm. A team led by Deborah Whalen, a cardiology nurse practitioner, and James Piepenbrink, the hospital's director of clinical engineering, did the opposite. They subtracted. Low-level warnings that called for no action stopped sounding. The warnings that often came just before a real emergency were upgraded to crisis alarms a nurse had to answer. And nurses could set the limits to fit each patient, instead of one setting for everyone.

Daily audible alarms fell to 1,424, a drop of eighty-nine percent. No incident reports involving cardiac monitoring were filed during the pilot. The noise fell to about seventy-two decibels, and the share of nurses who called it acceptable went from zero to sixty-four percent.

They said they could hear the alarms that mattered. The hospital extended the change to its other units, and the results were published in the Journal of Cardiovascular Nursing.

Nobody told the nurses to be more careful. Somebody made the room quieter, and the care came back on its own.

## What it means

Here is an odd fact about your senses: they are not very good at measuring the world. They are very good at noticing change. Keep adding stimulation and they recalibrate, the way a tongue raised on hot sauce finds plain soup tasteless. The soup did not get worse. The instrument got blunter. So the cure for a dull life is rarely more. It is less, held long enough for the senses to reset. Bruce Lee, the martial artist, built his method on removal: "Hack away at the unessential." Less, but better, is not a sacrifice. It is how you get your hearing back.

## If this is you

Maybe nothing feels interesting anymore. Work is flat. Church feels slow. Dinner with your family drags, and your hand finds the phone before you decide to reach for it. You assume the world got boring, or that you did.

Neither is likely. Your instrument is overloaded. News with breakfast, a podcast in the car, notifications all afternoon, a screen in bed. Each one is small and each one makes sense. But stack them for a year, and the quiet things (a child's long story, a chapter of Scripture, a walk with no soundtrack) cannot compete. That is not a defect in your character. It is what any sense does when it is shouted at all day.

The good news is that this one reverses. Take a few alarms off the wall and leave them off. Give it a few weeks, and the plain day starts to sound like something again.

**The move.** Pick one input to cut for thirty days: the news, social media, the car radio, sugar, the TV that runs in the background. Cut it today, all at once, not gradually. Put something plain in its place, like silence on the drive or a ten-minute walk after dinner. Each evening, write one line about something you noticed that you would have missed. After a week, read the lines back.

---

#### CARRY THIS

Turn down the noise and the signal comes back.

#### GO DEEPER IN THE CHANGE AGENT TOOL

Related principles in the tool: Guard the Empty Space, Signal Over Noise and Eliminate, Automate, Delegate, Intensify. Or type in your own problem, like "I can't focus," and the tool finds the principles that fit. Research Group members can open every one of them.

# 201



PRINCIPLE 201 OF 281 · THE INSTRUMENT

Sunk costs buy nothing forward

# Uncommit

*Sunk costs buy nothing forward*

For most of the twentieth century, an American woman with breast cancer could expect one operation: the radical mastectomy. The surgeon removed the breast, the chest muscles beneath it, and the lymph nodes under the arm. William Halsted had developed it at Johns Hopkins and published his results in 1894. For about seventy years it was simply what was done. Some surgeons went further, with "super-radical" versions that took even more.

It is easy to see why it lasted. A bigger operation looks like a bigger effort. Generations of surgeons had trained in it, built careers on it and taught it to the next class. Every woman who survived seemed like proof. To question it was to question every one of those operations.

Bernard Fisher, a surgeon at the University of Pittsburgh, questioned it anyway. He suspected breast cancer had often spread through the body by the time it was found, so cutting more around the tumor would not save more lives. Many colleagues accused him of putting women in danger.

Between July 1971 and September 1974, his group, the National Surgical Adjuvant Breast and Bowel Project, randomly assigned 1,665 women at thirty-four centers to the radical operation or to less surgery. Here is the telling detail. Among women whose nodes felt normal, about four in ten of those given the full operation turned out to have cancer in the nodes the surgeon removed. Another group of

such women had those nodes left in place. The twenty-five-year results came out in 2002. Survival was the same in every group. Today surgeons rarely perform the radical mastectomy.

Seventy years of doing something is not a reason to keep doing it. It is only seventy years.

## What it means

Here is a strange fact. The money and time you have already spent are the only things in your life that nothing you do next can change. And they are the things most likely to decide what you do next. The psychologist Daniel Kahneman spent a career showing how the mind keeps paying into what is already gone, and how anything becomes more precious simply because it is ours. The correction is one plain question: knowing what I know now, would I buy into this today, at this price? If not, letting go is not waste. It is making room for less, but better.

## If this is you

Some of what wears you out was chosen by a younger you, under different facts. The side business that has been about to turn for three years. The training plan that keeps hurting your knee. A board seat, a weekly meeting, a way your family runs its weekends that nobody remembers agreeing to. You keep going because stopping would mean the years were wasted.

They were not wasted. They taught you what you now know. But they cannot buy you anything tomorrow. Only today's choices can.

This is not quitting. Letting a dead commitment go is how you keep faith with the living ones: your wife, your kids, your health, the work that is actually yours to do. Admitting the mistake costs one hard

afternoon. Pride in it costs a little every week, for as long as you let it run.

### **The move.**

1. List your standing commitments, up to ten: the meetings, memberships, projects and obligations that renew without asking.
2. Beside each, answer: knowing what I know today, would I buy into this again at today's price? Yes or no.
3. Pick one doubtful line and quietly stop it for two weeks. Watch who notices. Usually, no one does.

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### **CARRY THIS**

The past gets no vote on your next hour.

### **GO DEEPER IN THE CHANGE AGENT TOOL**

Related principles in the tool: Quitting Before the Curve, Feedback, Not Failure and Decide Once. Or type in your own problem, like "I've put too much in to quit," and the tool finds the principles that fit. Research Group members can open every one of them.



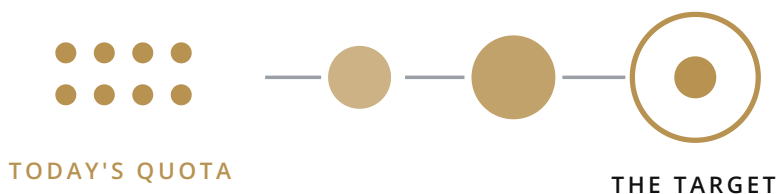
PART 3 OF 3

# Set things in order

With fewer things in your hands, put them in order: from the year down to the day, the most important first, and checked often enough that they stay put.

# 107

DIVIDED THROUGH THE CHAIN



PRINCIPLE 107 OF 281 · THE GAP

From the goal, backward through  
the math, down to today

# Reverse – Engineer the Target

*From the goal, backward through the math, down to today*

**I**n the early 1930s the United States set out to block the Colorado River with a concrete wall more than seven hundred feet tall, in a desert canyon on the border of Nevada and Arizona. It was the depth of the Great Depression, and work was scarce. In 1931 a group of firms calling itself Six Companies won the contract with a bid of about 48.9 million dollars. Their general superintendent was Frank Crowe.

The dam would need about 3.25 million cubic yards of concrete, and concrete gives off heat as it sets. So the engineers did something that sounds backward. They started from the finished dam and worked toward the first bucket. The answer was alarming. Poured as one great mass, the concrete would take about 125 years to cool, and it would crack itself apart along the way. The obvious way to build the dam was the one way that guaranteed there would be no dam.

So they divided it. The dam went up as separate columns, some fifty feet square, poured five feet at a time. Through them ran more than 582 miles of pipe, carrying river water and then ice-cold water from a refrigeration plant to draw the heat out. Every block had its place and its turn. The first concrete went in on June 6, 1933. The last went in on May 29, 1935.

Not every number was kind. Ninety-six men died at the site. But the work beat its schedule, and the dam was handed to the government on March 1, 1936, more than two years early.

Nobody poured a dam. They poured one five-foot block at a time, in an order the arithmetic had set before the first bucket moved.

## What it means

Big goals have a strange property: the bigger they are, the less they tell you to do on a Tuesday. A target only becomes doable when you work it backward. Start with the result, then divide it through every step between you and it: results to conversations, conversations to calls, calls to minutes. Use honest, modest rates. What falls out is a daily number, usually smaller than you feared and firmer than you hoped. That is a goal set in order. In Luke 14, Jesus describes the builder who sits down first and counts the cost. A dream is a number you have not divided yet.

## If this is you

Maybe your goal is so big that thinking about it makes you tired. Pay off the debt. Lose sixty pounds. Read the whole Bible. Build the business until it stops eating your evenings. Held whole, a goal like that does not pull you forward. It sits on your chest every morning and tells you that you are behind.

That is not a lack of discipline. It is a goal that has not been put in order yet. Divide it. Sixty pounds over a year is a little more than a pound a week. The Bible in a year is about three chapters a day. A quiet marriage is one real question at dinner tonight, not everything

fixed by Sunday. Counting is not a lack of faith. It is how faithful people finish. Once the number is small enough to do today, you will find that you can.

**The move.** Take one 30-day target and write the chain backward on a single sheet.

1. What result do I want by the deadline?
2. What has to happen just before that, and how often does it work? Use a modest rate.
3. Keep stepping back until you reach an action you control.
4. Divide by the days left.

Then do today's number. Only today's.

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#### CARRY THIS

Divide the dream until it fits inside today.

#### GO DEEPER IN THE CHANGE AGENT TOOL

Related principles in the tool: The War Map, Daily Deposits and The First 30 Days. Or type in your own problem, like "My goal feels too big," and the tool finds the principles that fit. Research Group members can open every one of them.

# 182

MORNING · THE ROCKS



EVENING · THE GRAVEL

PRINCIPLE 182 OF 281 · THE INSTRUMENT

Decision power decays through the day. Spend the morning on what matters

# Big Rocks First

*Decision power decays through the day. Spend the morning on what matters*

Every winter, waiting rooms fill with coughs, sore throats and stuffy noses. Most of these illnesses are caused by viruses, and antibiotics do nothing to a virus. Doctors know this. A needless prescription does the patient no good, can bring side effects, and helps breed germs that antibiotics can no longer kill. But the patient across the desk often wants something to show for the visit, and saying no takes time and a careful explanation.

In Boston, a team led by Dr. Jeffrey Linder of Brigham and Women's Hospital wondered whether the clock had a say in it. They gathered more than 21,000 visits for coughs, colds and other respiratory infections, seen by 204 clinicians at 23 primary care practices over 17 months starting in 2011. The clinics ran in two four-hour sessions, 8 a.m. to noon and 1 p.m. to 5 p.m. So the researchers sorted every visit by the hour of the session it fell in.

The patients who came in late in a session were no sicker than the ones who came in early. The doctors were the same doctors, with the same training and the same guidelines. But prescribing climbed as the session went on, and it was highest in the last hour. The same climb showed up in the morning session and again in the afternoon one. By the end of a session, about 5 percent more patients walked out with antibiotics than at the start.

The work appeared in JAMA Internal Medicine in October 2014. Linder's own reading was plain: clinic is demanding, and doctors wear down as a session goes on. A worn-down doctor takes the easy yes over the careful no.

Nobody in those clinics had changed their mind about antibiotics. They had simply run low on what it takes to hold a hard line, and the hour decided for them.

## What it means

We like to think a good decision depends on the person making it. It depends almost as much on when he makes it. Judgment is sharpest after rest and wears down with every choice that follows, so the order of your day is not a matter of taste. It is a law of the instrument. Stephen Covey made it visible with a jar, some big rocks and a pile of gravel. Put the rocks in first and the gravel settles around them. Pour the gravel first and the rocks never fit. Setting things in order starts with the clock.

## If this is you

Maybe your best hours go to your inbox. You answer forty messages before nine thirty and feel busy, even proud. Then by four o'clock the one thing that mattered (the hard phone call, the workout, the real talk with your wife, the prayer you meant to start the day with) gets moved to tomorrow. And tomorrow it happens again. So you decide you have a discipline problem.

You probably do not. You have an order problem. You spent the sharp blade on string and then tried to cut wood with a dull one. That is not weakness. It is the clock doing what the clock does to every doctor, pilot and parent alive.

The good news is that you need no new willpower for this. Same day, same you, same hours. Only the rocks go in first.

### **The move.**

1. Answer this plainly: what did you decide after four in the afternoon last week that deserved your nine in the morning mind?
2. Tonight, write tomorrow's one big rock on a card. One, not five.
3. Give it the first clear hour after you wake: phone in another room, mail closed, door shut.
4. Herd the messages and errands into the late afternoon, where a dull blade is still sharp enough.

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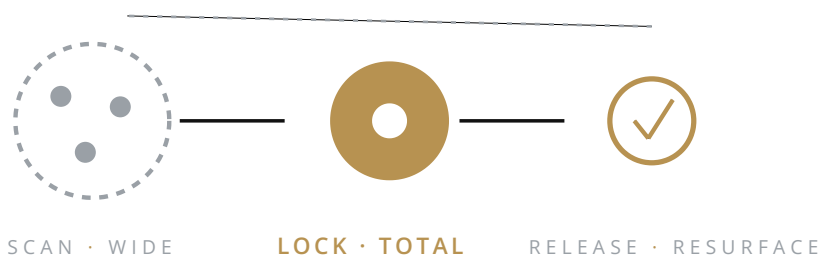
### **CARRY THIS**

Spend your sharp hours on your heavy things.

#### **GO DEEPER IN THE CHANGE AGENT TOOL**

Related principles in the tool: Find the Missing Hours, The State Is the Asset and Guard the Empty Space. Or type in your own problem, like “I never get to what matters,” and the tool finds the principles that fit. Research Group members can open every one of them.

# 149



PRINCIPLE 149 OF 281 · THE INSTRUMENT × THE GAP

Survey everything, choose one  
thing, then disappear into it

# Scan, Lock, Release

*Survey everything, choose one thing, then disappear into it*

Just before midnight on December 29, 1972, Eastern Air Lines Flight 401 was coming into Miami from New York. The plane was a Lockheed L-1011 TriStar, a brand new wide-body jet only four months out of the factory, with 176 people aboard. In the cockpit sat Captain Robert Loft, First Officer Albert Stockstill and Flight Engineer Donald Repo.

When Stockstill lowered the landing gear, one small green light failed to come on. That light was the signal that the nose wheel was locked down. Without it, nobody could be sure. So the controller cleared them to climb to 2,000 feet and circle west, out over the Everglades. The airplane went on autopilot, and the three men went to work on the light.

The lens assembly jammed as the captain and first officer tried to work it loose. Repo was sent down into the electronics bay beneath the cockpit to look at the nose gear through a small window. Investigators believe the captain leaned against the control column while turning to talk, and the autopilot quietly let go of its altitude. The jet began a gentle descent. A single chime sounded at the engineer's empty station. Outside there was nothing to see: night, swamp, no lights.

For about four minutes, three skilled men worked on a light while the airplane sank. Seconds before the end, Stockstill said, "We did something to the altitude." The jet hit the Everglades at 227 miles an

hour. 101 people died. 75 survived, and among the first to reach them was a local airboat pilot named Robert Marquis. The nose gear had been down the whole time. The bulb was burned out.

After this crash and others like it, airlines began training crews so that, whatever goes wrong, one pilot only flies. Nobody in that cockpit was lazy. All three were locked on, and no one was left to look up.

## What it means

Focus has a reputation as a pure virtue. It is not. It is a powerful beam, and everything depends on where it points. Deep work runs in three beats. Scan: look wide at the whole of your life and check it against where you mean to go. Lock: choose the one target that moves the most, and disappear into it. Release: when it is done, come up for air and scan again. Cal Newport, the computer scientist, calls this kind of undistracted depth the defining skill of our age. The trouble lives in the half-states: scanning forever without locking, or locking without ever looking up.

## If this is you

Maybe you live in one of the half-states. Some weeks you scan all day long. Email, news, the bank balance, the group chat, and nothing ever gets your full weight. Other seasons you lock so hard you vanish into a launch, a deal or a build, and when you surface six months later your health has slipped and your daughter is taller and quieter.

Both feel like hard work. Neither is order. The fix is not to care less. It is a rhythm: look wide, choose one, go deep, come up. Decide ahead of time what is allowed to break the lock. Family, health and a true

fire make the list. Everything else waits. Some people will be annoyed, and that is a cheap price. You are not short on effort. You are short on a rhythm that tells your effort where to go.

### **The move.**

1. Scan: take ten minutes and write one honest line each on your faith, your health, your family and your work.
2. Lock: circle the one line that, if it moved, would move the most. Then answer: how do you know?
3. Block tomorrow's first ninety minutes for it, and write down the only three things allowed to interrupt.
4. Release: put a time on the calendar this week when you will come up and scan again.

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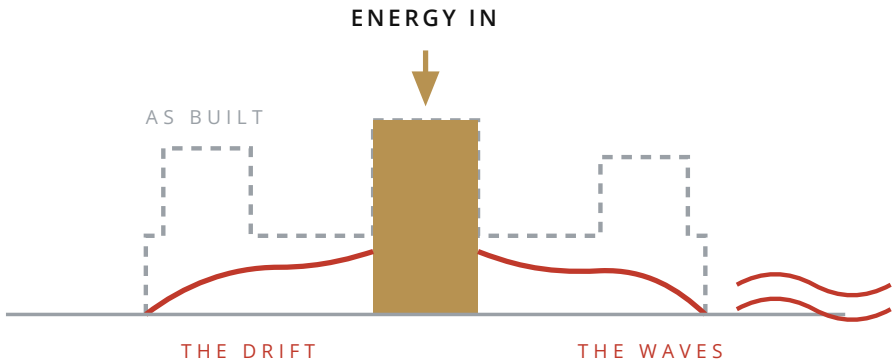
### **CARRY THIS**

Go deep, but someone still has to fly.

#### **GO DEEPER IN THE CHANGE AGENT TOOL**

Related principles in the tool: The Priority Equation, Does It Make the Boat Go Faster and Plan, Then Leave It Alone. Or type in your own problem, like "I'm busy but nothing moves," and the tool finds the principles that fit. Research Group members can open every one of them.

# 265



## PRINCIPLE 265 OF 281 · NATURAL LAW

Order decays by default. Only imported energy holds it.

# The Arrow of Entropy

*Order decays by default. Only imported energy holds it.*

The bridge between Point Pleasant, West Virginia, and Gallipolis, Ohio, opened in 1928. It was coated in aluminum paint, so people called it the Silver Bridge. It hung from chains made of long steel bars called eyebars, linked end to end like a giant bicycle chain. Bridges of that kind usually used four to six bars in each link. This one used two.

It was designed in the age of the Model T, a car that weighed about 1,500 pounds. By the 1960s, cars twice that heavy and trucks carrying as much as 60,000 pounds were crossing it regularly. And the whole time, quietly, water and stress were working on the steel.

On Friday, December 15, 1967, in rush hour, one eyebar in one chain gave way. The fault began as a corrosion crack about a tenth of an inch deep, tucked inside a joint where nobody could have seen it without taking the chain apart. With only two bars in the link, there was no spare. In about a minute the bridge was in the Ohio River. Thirty-two vehicles went with it, and 46 people died.

We like our disasters to have villains. This one had none. Nobody sabotaged the Silver Bridge, and nothing dramatic happened to it that day. The steel simply did what every ordered thing does when it is left alone: it drifted toward disorder, one small step at a time, for almost forty years.

The country learned the lesson the hard way. The next year, Congress created the first national bridge inspection program, and bridges have been checked on a schedule ever since. Order does not

keep itself. It holds only as long as somebody keeps putting work into it.

## What it means

Here is a thought to comfort anyone with a messy garage: disorder is not proof you did something wrong. It is simply the odds. There are very few ways for a kitchen drawer to be organized and thousands of ways for it not to be, so every random nudge lands on a worse one. Rudolf Clausius named this entropy in 1865, and Ludwig Boltzmann later showed it comes down to counting. It is a real physical law, not a mood. Order holds only while energy keeps coming in. So upkeep is not a sign you built badly. It is the rent on having built at all.

## If this is you

Maybe something in your life has gone slack and you cannot point to the day it happened. A friendship faded. Your marriage feels thinner. Your Bible gathers dust on the nightstand. You keep looking for the big event that explains it, and there is none.

That is entropy, and it is better news than it sounds. Nothing broke. The small daily work stopped, and the drift did the rest. If nothing dramatic caused it, nothing dramatic is needed to fix it.

In the wilderness, Israel gathered manna every morning, each according to his eating. Those who kept some overnight against Moses' word woke to find it had bred worms and stank. Love, health and faith keep the same terms. Paul put it plainly: "Let all things be done decently and in order." Not heroically. In order. You do not need a big Saturday. You need a steady Tuesday.

**The move.** Ask yourself the inspector's question: what do I use every day and check never? Your body, your marriage, your money, your car, your prayer life. Pick one. Put a fifteen-minute check on your calendar for the same day and time every week, with your own name beside it as the owner. Do the first one today, before the drift gets another week.

---

#### CARRY THIS

Order is rented, never owned. Pay a little every week.

#### GO DEEPER IN THE CHANGE AGENT TOOL

Related principles in the tool: Decide Once, A System Beats a Good Person and Damp the Swing. Or type in your own problem, like "Things keep slipping," and the tool finds the principles that fit. Research Group members can open every one of them.

# That is the taste

Twelve principles. One job. If you did even three of the moves, you already know more about change than most plans ever find out: there is a start, a finish, and a distance, and you are the one holding the tape measure.

These twelve came from the Change Agent tool, which holds all 281 principles, grouped under five roots. Each root is a single sentence about how the world works, and every principle grows out of one of them, or out of the place where two of them meet.

The other 269 are waiting for you in the Change Agent tool. Type in the problem you are facing, in your own words, and it finds the principles that fit. Read them, listen to them, and try the moves. Members of our research group get full access.



## 1 job

Close the gap between where things are and where they should be.



## 9 foundations

The ground everything else stands on.



## 5 roots

Each one a single sentence about how the world works.



## 281 principles

The street names. You have just walked twelve of them.

THE FIVE ROOTS

# Every principle grows from one of these

|   |                       |                                                                                                            |     |
|---|-----------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----|
| 1 | <b>The Gap</b>        | Everything has a current state and a desired state. Closing that distance is the whole job.                | 81  |
| 2 | <b>Natural Law</b>    | Reality behaves the same way whether or not you agree, and time compounds every cause.                     | 74  |
| 3 | <b>The Instrument</b> | The human instrument is fallible. Correct it from outside, and trust the test, not your head.              | 74  |
| 4 | <b>Becoming</b>       | The biggest gap to close is your own. You are becoming, not being.                                         | 76  |
| 5 | <b>The Arena</b>      | Nothing great is built alone, and power is a game being played on you. Build with people; know their laws. | 133 |

The number on the right is how many principles touch each root. More than half sit where two roots meet, so they are counted under both. The twelve in this book come from three of them: The Gap, Natural Law and The Instrument.

ONE SENTENCE HOLDS ALL FIVE

A person, holding a fallible instrument, closes a gap, in a world that runs on laws, among other people.

Those five are the roots. Where two of them meet is a joint, and there are exactly ten. Every principle in the tool sits on one root or one joint, never more.

# Reading this changed nothing

I say that with affection.

You have just read a book of principles, and the awkward truth about principles is that reading them does nothing at all. A law you have only read is a rumor. A law you have tried on a Tuesday, in your own business or your own kitchen, is yours.

This whole book stands on one of its own roots. Trust the test, not your head. So it would be strange to end by asking you to agree with me. I would much rather you went and found out.

That is what our research group is for. We take the Laws of Change out of the book and into real companies and real homes, and then we compare notes on what held up. Some of it works the first time. Some of it works the fourth time. All of it is more fun in company. Another root says that nothing great is built alone, so I am only following instructions.

So here is the one thing I will ask of you. Join us. You already have the hard part, which is a gap worth closing and the nerve to look at it. Come and find out what you can do with it.



## YOUR NEXT STEP

# Join our research group.

This is where we explore how to apply the Laws of Change in real companies and real homes, and compare notes on what held up.

Members get full access to the Change Agent tool: all 281 principles, every story and every source. Type in the problem you are facing, and it shows you the principles that fit.

### Two ways in:

1. **Book a call.** A short call with me to see if the Research Group is right for you: [calendly.com/jean-eng2/30min](https://calendly.com/jean-eng2/30min)
2. **Join the Skool group.** Come straight into the Research Group: [skool.com/science-of-business-7140](https://skool.com/science-of-business-7140)

## jlouishardy.com

Jean Louis Hardy